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Phonological Patterns in the Hebrew Bible: A Century of Studies in Sound

Arthur Keefer
University of Cambridge, UK

Abstract

This article traces the history of scholarship on sound patterns in the Hebrew Bible. Beginning in the nineteenth century, studies devoted to biblical Hebrew phonological patterns or devices entertain questions and debates that continue for over a century. Many works contribute concepts, frameworks, definitions and typologies to the phonic repertoire. Others employ such tools by identifying, organizing and explaining sounds in the biblical texts themselves. These two sides of scholarship—theory and application—characterize the field and include recurring questions of how to classify or define sound patterns, and also how to determine sound's function. This article attends to the landmark studies and turning points from 1865 to 2015, especially underscoring the various terminologies. It is structured according to key scholars and by decades that share a common approach.

Keywords

Alliteration, assonance, consonance, Hebrew, Hebrew Bible, paronomasia, phonology, rhyme, sound, sound play, wordplay.

Introduction

Language lends itself to sound patterns. While words communicate visually, they also communicate aurally through sounds created in the mind or by the spoken word. The Hebrew Bible was no exception to this, and its authors employed sound as a means of communication. However, discerning uses of sound in the Hebrew Bible depends upon the pronunciation of the Hebrew language. The pointed text of the Hebrew Bible, the version of the Tiberian Masoretes from roughly the tenth century CE, may offer a dependable form of the language

Corresponding author:
Arthur Keefer, Faculty of Divinity, University of Cambridge, West Road, Cambridge, CB3 9BS, UK.
Email: ak903@cam.ac.uk

ingredients of sound and meaning (e.g., Nease 2012; Wilson 2013; cf. Lee and Scott 2009). Otherwise, Kabergs (2014) briefly points out wordplay in Song 8.6a, and Ron (2014) revisits a famous sound pattern, the 'wordplay' between 'naked' and 'cunning' in Gen. 2.25 and 3.1. Most interesting about Ron's article is his caution towards attributing anything other than aesthetic significance to the sound pattern. Against the many meanings or 'lessons' suggested by modern interpreters, he states that

> None of these lessons are particularly profound, and it may well be that the primary motivation for using similar sounding words for both 'naked' and 'cunning' was to fashion an interesting and pleasant narrative, with the possibility of some additional message or lesson as a welcome side effect (pp. 4-5).

Conclusion

Over the course of a century, questions remain: what did the biblical authors intend to achieve with sound patterns, and how do these patterns function? Recent studies have gravitated towards the significance of sound, particularly as it relates to meaning and might contribute to the wider literary context. Still, an ebb and flow characterizes the century-plus of scholarship on sound patterns in the Hebrew Bible. Many works contribute concepts, frameworks, definitions and typologies to the phonic repertoire. Others employ such tools by identifying, organizing and explaining sounds in biblical texts. These two sides of scholarship have and will, I hope, maintain a mutually beneficial relationship. To facilitate this, it seems more work ought to be done with definitions, such as a uniform typology of sound patterns that provides a standardized compass for other studies. Additionally, methodological issues, especially with regard to detecting the deliberateness of sound devices, have not been adequately evaluated or explored. Except for Proverbs and Song of Songs, few books from the Hebrew Bible have been thoroughly examined for their sound patterns, and the increasing concentration on identifying sound in particular biblical passages suggests a fruitful direction for research. Only interaction with the text itself will unveil the function of sound patterns.

After over a century of studies, there seems to be no question that sound is significant for the Hebrew Bible. The question is, how is it significant? Attention to definitions, method, function and the text itself will hopefully foster another fruitful century of research in phonological patterns.

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